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THEATRE ARTS

FILM ANALYSIS

Film Analysis: Shot, Cut and Sound

A ZikShare teaching unit, written for this shelf

A working vocabulary for reading a film: shot size, camera angle, movement, editing, sound and mise-en-scène, applied scene by scene.

WHAT THIS UNIT COVERS

- shot size
- camera angle
- editing
- sound
- mise-en-scène

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The shot

Shot size runs from the extreme long shot, which places a figure in a landscape, to the extreme close-up, which makes an eye the whole world. Each size answers a different question: where are we, who is this, what are they feeling, what are they noticing? A film that stays in medium shots for two hours has decided that nobody's inner life matters very much.

Camera angle carries judgement before a word is spoken: low angle gives power, high angle gives vulnerability, a Dutch tilt gives unease, and an eye-level shot pretends to be neutral.

The cut

Editing is the creation of time and meaning. Continuity editing hides the cut so the story flows; montage makes the cut visible so an argument can be built from fragments. A cut on action joins two shots into one movement; a cut to a reaction shot tells you what the previous shot meant.

Watch a scene with the sound off and count the cuts. Note where the cut happens: on a line, on a look, on a movement, or after the movement has finished. The rhythm is the meaning.

Sound

Diegetic sound belongs to the world of the film - a radio in the room, a car outside. Non-diegetic sound is added for the audience - a score, a narrator. The interesting cases are the ones in between: music a character can hear, a sound that turns out to be in someone's head.

Sound does more narrative work than students expect. A scene with the dialogue removed and the ambience kept will often tell you exactly what the scene is about. Try it.

Mise-en-scène and the long take

Mise-en-scène is everything in the frame: set, costume, light, colour, blocking, the position of the camera. A long take without cuts puts the whole of that arrangement on display at once and asks the audience to choose where to look - which is why directors use it for moments of moral complexity.

For analysis, describe before you interpret. What is in the frame, where is it, what colour is it, what is moving? Then ask what the arrangement is doing.

Reading a sequence: a worked method

Choose a sequence of two to four minutes. Watch it three times. First for what happens. Second with a notebook, writing the timecode of every cut and the size of every shot. Third with the sound off, then once more with the picture off.

You will end with a shot list and a sound list. Lay them side by side and look for the pattern: how long the shots are, whether the cuts land on dialogue or on movement, where the music enters and leaves, which shot is held longer than the rest. The held shot is almost always the one the sequence is about.

Then write one paragraph that states what the sequence does and cites three pieces of evidence from your lists. That paragraph, repeated across a film, is a film analysis. It is slower than an impression and much harder to argue

with.

The vocabulary, exactly

Learn the terms so you can use them without hesitating: extreme long shot, long shot, medium long shot, medium shot, medium close-up, close-up, extreme close-up; high angle, low angle, eye level, overhead, Dutch angle; pan, tilt, track, dolly, crane, handheld, zoom.

Then learn the editing terms: cut, dissolve, fade, wipe, match cut, jump cut, cross-cutting, montage, insert, reaction shot, long take. A shot list written in this vocabulary can be compared with another, which is what analysis requires.

Exercises

1. Break down a two-minute scene shot by shot: size, angle, movement, duration, sound.
2. Watch the same scene with the sound off, then with the picture off, and describe what each carries.
3. Compare a continuity-edited scene with a montage sequence and explain what each makes possible.

Where to read more

David Bordwell and Kristin Thompson, Film Art: An Introduction (any edition)

Louis Giannetti, Understanding Movies (any edition)

James Monaco, How to Read a Film (1977)

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